

Palace of Knossos

Decorated with frescoes on its walls depicting sports and religious ceremonies, the Palace of Knossos (built c.1700–1400 BCE) on the Aegean island of Crete was the ceremonial and political centre of Minoan civilization and culture, abandoned c.1380–1100 BCE. The palace complex was two storeys high and built around a large, open, square courtyard, comprising a maze of workrooms, living spaces and storerooms.

Colonnaded rooms were used for ceremonial purposes, and were usually on the first floor. Within, great columns were made not of stone, but of cypress tree trunks turned upside down and mounted on simple stone bases before being painted red. Although the palace has been immortalized in Greek mythology as the site of the Labyrinth (home of the half-man, half-bull Minotaur), it was actually well ventilated and light, with cool, sunlit rooms offering magnificent views. Yet there was no cohesive design to the rambling, extended building complex, which was added to over centuries of use.

